Sourdough
for the Rest of Us

Perfection Not Required

Henry Hunter

Sourdough for the Rest of Us:

Perfection Not Required

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Dedication

To the members of *Baking Great Bread at Home*—your curiosity, resilience, and shared bread wins inspire every page of this book. Keep rising.

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Introduction

Welcome to the Sourdough Tribe

"My first loaf could've doubled as a hockey puck. Now I'm here. You've got this."

Sourdough isn't just bread; it's a lifeline. A ritual. A way to turn flour, water, and wild yeast into something alive. It's a process that teaches patience, problem-solving, and—let's be honest—how to embrace a few epic failures along the way.

When I first started baking sourdough, I scoured every blog, watched every video, and still managed to produce loaves that could shatter windows. I wished for a guide that didn't take itself too seriously, something that covered the science without the snobbery and offered real-world solutions when things inevitably went sideways.

Oh, and before we dive in, some links in this book are affiliate links. If you decide to make a purchase through them, I might earn a small commission—at no extra cost to you. These proceeds help fund more resources for our Baking Great Bread at Home community.

That’s what this book is. It’s a mashup of everything I wish I’d known, plus tips, hacks, and facepalm moments from our 50,000+ Facebook group members who’ve been there, done that, and (probably) eaten the dense brick of their mistakes.

How to Use This Book

This isn't a traditional cookbook where you follow every page in order. Instead, treat it like a **choose-your-own-adventure guide**:

✅ **New to sourdough?** Read it start to finish. You'll get the full breakdown, from starter to bake.

✅ **Dough disaster?** Jump straight to **Troubleshooting** before you rage-quit and throw it out.

✅ **Busy life?** Flip to **Schedules** for realistic baking timelines that fit into your day.

✅ **Feeling experimental?** Check out **Variations & Hacks** to make your bread uniquely yours.

So, whether you're here to bake your first loaf or perfect your technique, welcome. You're officially part of the **Sourdough Tribe**—a world where every baker has battle scars (and great bread stories). Let's get baking.

Chapter 1

Your Sourdough Starter—The Drama Queen of the Kitchen

If you've ever felt personally attacked by a jar of bubbling flour and water, welcome to the world of sourdough. Your starter is a **living, breathing diva**—demanding, moody, and occasionally unpredictable. But once you learn how to handle its quirks, it'll reward you with the best bread you've ever tasted.

Think of your starter as a **low-maintenance pet** that lives in your kitchen. It doesn't need walks or belly rubs, but it does need food, warmth, and patience. Follow this guide, and in **seven days**, you'll have a bubbly, active culture that's ready to raise your bread game.

Building Your Starter: A 7-Day Diary with Pictures

🔧 *Day 1: The Flour & Water Wedding*

✓ **Looks like:** Glue.

✓ **Smells like:** Wet flour.

✓ **What to do:** Mix **100g flour + 100g water** in a jar. Cover loosely with a lid. Walk away.

📌 **Reality Check:** This stage is boring. Nothing exciting will happen today. Stay calm.

🔧 *Day 2: The Waiting Game*

✓ **Looks like:** Like Day 1.

✓ **It smells like:** Mild, possibly slightly sweet.

✓ **What to do:** Stir the mixture to aerate. No feeding required today.

📌 **Reality Check:** It's normal not to see much activity yet.

🔧 *Day 3: The Swamp Monster Phase*

✓ **Looks like:** A science experiment gone wrong (*hooch alert!*)

✓ **Smells like:** Old apples or funky socks.

✓ **What to do:** If there's liquid on top (*hooch*), pour it off or stir it back in (your tanginess call). Discard half and feed it **50g flour + 50g water.**

📌 **Reality Check:** If your starter smells like acetone (nail polish remover), it's just **hungry.** Feed it **twice a day for a couple of days**, and it'll mellow out.

🔧 *Day 4: Building Momentum*

✓ **Looks like:** More bubbles, slightly risen.

✓ **Smells like:** Sour, like yogurt.

✓ What **to do:** Repeat the Day 3 feeding: discard half, then add 50g flour and 50g water.

📌 **Reality Check:** Consistency is crucial; maintain regular feedings.

🔍 *Day 5: Is This Bread Magic?*

✓ **Looks like:** Bubbly pancake batter.

✓ **Smells like:** Yogurt and ripe fruit.

✓ **Group Hack:** If it's sluggish, stir in **10g rye flour & 10g of water**, it's like espresso for starters.

📌 **Reality Check:** If your starter still looks dead, don't panic. Give it **one more day** of consistent feeding. It should be the color of the flour you're using.

🔍 *Day 6: Almost There*

✓ **Looks like:** Active, doubling in size between feedings.

✓ **Smells like:** Pleasantly sour.

✓ **What to do:** Repeat the feeding: discard half, then add 50g flour and 50g water.

📌 **Reality Check:** Monitor activity; consistent bubbling and rising are good signs.

🔍 *Day 7: The Moment of Truth*

✓ **Looks like:** Vigorous bubbles, doubled in volume.

✓ **Smells like:** Rich, sour scent.

✓ **The Float Test:** Drop a spoonful into a cup of water. If it floats, it's ready for baking. If not, feed it once more and wait another 12-24 hours.

📌 **Reality Check:** Not every starter is ready in exactly seven days. If you are still a bit sleepy, keep feeding it—it'll wake up soon. During the initial days, a variety of microorganisms, including unwanted bacteria, are present. Regular feedings create an increasingly acidic environment, favoring beneficial lactic acid bacteria and wild yeasts, which naturally get rid of harmful bacteria. Be sure your starter is active, bubbly, and has a pleasant, slightly sour aroma before baking. Patience and consistent care are key to developing a robust and healthy sourdough starter.

Starter FAQs (From the Group's Top Posts)

🔹 **"Why does mine smell like nail polish remover?"**
→ It's starving. Feed it **twice daily for two days**, and it'll calm down.

- **“Black spots! Is it mold?”**

→ If it’s fuzzy, yes (*toss it!*). If it’s just a dark liquid, nope—that’s hooch. Stir it back in or pour it off.

- **“Can I use tap water?”**

→ If your water **tastes like a swimming pool**, filter it. Chlorine can kill the wild yeast.

- **“My starter doubled once but now it’s lazy. Help!”**

→ It probably ran out of food too fast. Feed it **1:1:1** (equal parts starter, flour, and water) and check the temperature—it thrives between **75-80°F (24-27°C).**

Bonus Tips: How to Keep Your Starter Happy (Long-Term)

✓ **Name it.** (*Doughlores, Bready Mercury, Yeastie Boys—pick your favorite.*) Naming your starter makes you more likely to keep it alive.

✓ **Give it a vacation.** If you're not baking for a while, store it in the **fridge** and feed it once a week.

✓ **Forgot about it for a month?** It might still be revivable. Scrape off any dark top layer and feed it like crazy.

Pro tip*: If you've been following the traditional advice to* ***discard half your starter*** *and it feels wasteful, consider this tweak. Instead of dumping half, try keeping* ***50g of starter*** *and feeding it with* ***50g of flour and 50g of water****. This keeps your ratios in check while minimizing waste, especially in those early days.*

Yeast Water:

A Low-Maintenance Alternative to Sourdough Starter

If keeping a sourdough starter alive feels like a full-time job, you're not alone. Many bakers love the idea of natural fermentation but don't want the commitment of regular feedings. That's where **yeast water** comes in.

Yeast water is a wild yeast culture made by fermenting fruit, herbs, or even vegetables in water. It works similarly to a sourdough starter, but instead of feeding it with flour, you let the natural sugars from the ingredients ferment. This creates an active, bubbly liquid that can be used to leaven bread—without the need for daily maintenance.

Why Try Yeast Water?

✓ **Less Maintenance** – No daily feedings, just occasional refreshes.
✓ **Naturally Sweet & Fruity Flavors** – The fermentation ingredients can add subtle flavors to your bread.
✓ **Great for Experimentation** – You can try different fruits and herbs to create unique profiles.

✓ **No Discard Waste** – Unlike a sourdough starter, there's no regular discard.

How It Compares to Sourdough Starter

Feature	Yeast Water	Sourdough Starter
Feeding	Occasional	Regular (daily/weekly)
Complexity	Simple, beginner-friendly	Requires routine upkeep
Fermentation Time	Longer (24-48 hrs)	Faster once active
Flavor	Mild, slightly sweet	Tangy, complex
Baking Process	Works well, but dough may need longer proofing	Well-developed fermentation control

Yeast water can be used in place of commercial yeast in many bread recipes. While it takes a bit longer to ferment, it's an excellent option for those who love the idea of wild yeast but don't want to commit to a starter.

If you're curious about trying yeast water, I've put together an entire book on the subject: **The Yeast Water Handbook**. It covers everything from making your own yeast water to troubleshooting and recipes.

Welcome to the Sourdough Club

Congrats! If you've made it this far, you now have a **living sourdough starter**—a tiny ecosystem that will help you bake incredible bread. You're officially part of the sourdough world, where failures are just learning experiences, and every loaf is a step toward mastery.

So, what's next? Time to **bake your first loaf.** Get ready to see what your little jar of flour and water can do!

Now that you've successfully created your own starter, let's move on to the next crucial step in your sourdough journey. With your bubbling jar of yeast and bacteria ready for action, it's time to learn how to transform it into a strong, flavorful dough, starting with a technique that will revolutionize your baking process.

Chapter 2

Fermentolyse—The Secret to Flavor & Gluten

If you've ever struggled with dense, lifeless sourdough or dough that tears like wet paper, you're not alone. Many bakers swear by **autolyse**—the process of mixing flour and water before adding anything else—to help gluten develop.

But I'm here to make a case for its cooler, funkier cousin: **fermentolyse**.

This technique jumpstarts fermentation by adding starter right from the beginning. It builds better structure, boosts flavor, and makes sure your dough doesn't slack off during the bulk fermentation stage. It's a game-changer, and once you try it, you won't go back.

Autolyse vs. Fermentolyse: What's the Difference?

At first glance, they look similar, but one packs a much bigger punch.

🥯 **Autolyse** (Classic Method)

✔️ Flour + water only.

✔️ Rest time allows gluten to develop naturally.

✔️ Starter and salt are added later.

✔️ Great for long fermentation but requires careful timing.

🔥 **Fermentolyse** (The Upgrade)

✔️ Flour + water + starter mixed from the start.

✔️ Fermentation begins earlier, meaning more complex flavors.

✔️ Gluten structure develops faster (less kneading required).

✔️ Works especially well in cooler kitchens where dough needs a boost.

📌 **Why You Should Care:**

Fermentolyse gives you **stronger dough and richer flavor**

with less effort. It's like taking the shortcut that somehow works *better* than the long road.

The Science Lite Version: Why Fermentolyse Works

When you mix flour and water alone (autolyse), enzymes break down starches and proteins, setting the stage for gluten development. But when you add your **starter** right away (fermentolyse), you introduce wild yeast and bacteria earlier in the process.

✅ **Result?** The wild yeast gets a head start, creating a deeper, tangier flavor and a stronger dough that holds its shape better.

🚀 **Bonus:** It also helps if your kitchen is on the chilly side.

Fermentolyse compensates for colder temperatures by encouraging fermentation right away, so your dough isn't sluggish during bulk fermentation.

How to Know If Your Fermentolyse Worked

A successful fermentolyse gives you dough that feels alive. After the rest period, you should notice:

✔ **Smoother Dough:** It should feel less like a sticky mess and more like silk. *(Think: smooth jazz playlist, not rock concert.)*

✔ **Tiny Surface Bubbles:** If your dough looks like it has a light champagne fizz under the surface, you nailed it.

✔ **Better Stretch & Strength:** Pick up a piece of dough—if it stretches easily without tearing, your gluten is on point.

How to Use Fermentolyse in Your Baking

To try it out, swap your autolyse step with fermentolyse in any recipe. The process is simple:

1. Mix **flour, water, and starter** together until fully incorporated.

2. Let it rest for **30-60 minutes.**
3. Add salt
   Dimpling it in with your fingertips after the rest, then proceed as usual.

That's it! A small tweak for big results.

Final Thoughts: Upgrade Your Dough, Effortlessly

Fermentolyse is an easy trick to get better bread **without extra work.** It helps you bake loaves with **better structure, richer flavor, and improved texture**—all by making one simple change.

So, next time you reach for that bag of flour, ask yourself: *Why wait?* Let your starter get in on the action early, and let the dough do the work for you. Watch an example of me dimpling in the salt.

Chapter 3

Henry's Foolproof Loaf—Step-by-Step, No BS

Introduction

When I first started baking sourdough, I was determined to master the perfect loaf—a balance of crisp crust, soft crumb, and deep, complex flavor. I experimented endlessly, trying different methods, flour blends, and hydration levels, and what I discovered was that simplicity often wins.

This recipe is the culmination of years of trial and error. It's been tested in kitchens around the world, shared by thousands of bakers, and designed to eliminate guesswork. Whether you're a beginner or an experienced sourdough enthusiast, this loaf is approachable and consistent.

With **75% hydration** and a method that prioritizes fermentation and structure, it's as rewarding to make as it is to eat. Let's bake!

Ingredients

(Yields one loaf)

Ingredient	Metric	Volume (approx.)
Bread flour	500g	4 cups
Water (lukewarm)	375g	1 ½ cups
Active sourdough starter	100g	½ cup
Salt (flaky sea salt)	10g	2 tsp

Equipment

- Mixing bowl
- Bench scraper
- Proofing basket (banneton)
- Brød & Taylor Baking Shell (*affiliate link*) or Dutch oven
- Digital scale

- ModKitchn Bread Sling (*affiliate link*) or parchment paper
- Lame or sharp knife for scoring

"Hydration: 75% | Starter Percentage: 20% | Salt: 2% | These ratios ensure consistent dough behavior regardless of batch size."

Method

1. Mix & Fermentolyse

(10 minutes active, 45 minutes rest)

- In a large bowl, mix **500g flour**, **375g water**, and **100g starter** until no dry flour remains.
- Cover and rest for **45 minutes**.
- Add **10g salt** and mix using the **Rubaud method**:
    - Cup your hand, scoop from underneath the dough, lift upward, and let it fall back.
    - Repeat for **10 minutes** until smooth and elastic.

2. Stretch & Fold (or Coil Fold)

(3 sets of folds every 45 minutes)

- **Stretch & Fold**: Lift one side of the dough upward, fold over itself. Rotate bowl and repeat.

Stretch and Fold

- **Coil Fold** (gentler option):
  - Wet hands, lift the center of the dough, and let it coil under itself. Rotate bowl and repeat.
- Perform **3 sets** with **45 minutes** between each. Dough should feel strong and less sticky.

3. Shape the Dough

- After the final fold, rest dough for **30 minutes** in the bowl.
- Turn dough onto a lightly floured surface And gently stretch it into a square.

- **Fold the dough like a letter**:

  - Fold the bottom edge to center,
  - Stretch the corners inward
  - Fold top edge down over the previous folds.
- Roll the dough into a tight bundle To create surface tension, ensuring the scenes are pinched and sealed.
- Place the dough seam-side up in a floured banneton.
- Let it rest on counter for **1 hour**, then refrigerate for **8–24 hours**.

4. Preheat & Score

- Preheat oven to **475°F (245°C)** with Dutch oven and lid inside.

- *Pro Tip*: For intricate scoring, freeze dough **15 minutes** during preheat.

"Freezing the dough for 30 minutes While your oven preheat before scoring improves structure."

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5. Bake

- Carefully turn the dough onto a piece of parchment paper or a bread sling, so it's seam-side down.
- **Using a sharp tool (like a bread lame or razor blade), score the top of the dough:**
  1. **Depth:** Approximately 1/2 inch (1.25 cm) deep.
  2. **Angle:** Hold the blade at a 45° angle to create an "ear" during baking.

- Bake **covered** for **22 minutes**, then **uncovered** for **10–15 minutes** until golden and internal temp reaches **200°F (93°C)** or sounds hollow when you tap it on the bottom
- Cool completely before slicing.

Pro Tip: *Creating surface tension during shaping helps the loaf maintain its form and contributes to better oven spring. Ensuring that seams are properly sealed prevents them from opening during baking, leading to a more uniform crumb and crust. For a visual demonstration of these techniques, you might find this video helpful:*

Troubleshooting & Common Mistakes

Issue	Cause	Solution
Dough too sticky	High hydration	Use wet hands and coil folds.
Dense loaf	Underproved	Extend bulk fermentation.
Flat loaf	Weak gluten/shaping	Focus on tension during shaping.
Pale crust	Oven not hot enough	Preheat thoroughly.

Nutrition Facts

(Per slice, ~50g)

Calories	Carbs	Protein	Fat
110	22g	4g	0.5g

Final Thoughts

This sourdough recipe is my pride and joy. It's the loaf I bake when I want to impress or just enjoy something familiar and comforting. Sourdough baking is a journey, and every loaf teaches you something new.

Windowpane Test

Share your results!

Post photos in [Baking Great Bread at Home]() and tag **#HenryHunter**. Let's keep inspiring each other!

Scoring Your Loaf—Guiding the Bake

Once your dough is shaped and proofed, it's time to score it. Scoring isn't just about making it look good (though it definitely helps.) It controls how your loaf expands in the oven. Without it, your dough will burst unpredictably, and you'll get a lopsided loaf instead of that controlled, even rise.

The process is the same whether you're working with yeasted dough or sourdough. The loaf in the photo? Yeasted. It doesn't matter. I treat them the same when I score them.

The Method I Use

First, dust the top of the loaf with a little finishing flour—the same flour you used in your recipe. This isn't just for looks. It helps you see your marks before you start cutting, so everything stays even.

Next, I take a piece of baker's twine or dental floss and lightly mark an X on top of the dough at 90-degree angles. This gives me a guide before I commit with the blade.

Inside the four triangles that I create, I take the string and mark a center line down each one. That's where the leaves go. For those, I slice at an angle toward the center line on both sides, keeping the cuts quick and controlled. The goal is to just break the surface—what I call the *epidermis* of the dough, so you get a nice contrast when it bakes. Then, I take the tip of my blade and barely drag it down that center line, just

enough to make a mark. It'll open up slightly in the oven, but it won't blow out.

Now comes the expansion score, the deep one. The two lines that form the X? Those get cut much deeper, about ¼ to ½ an inch, depending on how much I want them to open. If you want to exaggerate the ear, take a small pair of scissors and snip just under the edge of those cuts, giving them a head start to lift and bloom.

One more trick: I pop my dough in the freezer for 15-20 minutes while my Dutch oven preheats. This firms up the surface so it's easier to score, especially in warm weather when dough softens fast.

That's it. The next step? Straight into the oven.

Wire Monkey Lames

The 7-Minute Score

Most bakers score their dough once before baking and leave it at that. But if you're looking for a way to make your loaves even more decorative, try what I call the **7-Minute Score**.

What Is It?

The 7-Minute Score is a **secondary scoring technique** done just after your bread has started its oven spring. About **7 minutes into baking**, the dough will begin expanding, opening up along the original score. At this point, you go in and make a second, shallower cut along the same line.

What Does It Do?

This technique allows the loaf to **open up in layers**, creating a more dramatic, defined ear or design. It's especially useful for high-hydration doughs or decorative scoring, where you want crisp, clean edges.

How to Do It Safely

1. **Score as usual** – Before baking, make your initial cuts as you normally would.

2. **Bake for 7 minutes** – Let the bread begin its oven spring.
3. **Remove the Dutch oven from the oven** – Using **heat-resistant gloves**, carefully pull the Dutch oven out and place it on the stovetop. **Do not try to score while it's still inside the oven.**
4. **Take off the lid and re-score** – With a **sharp lame or razor**, lightly retrace your original score. The dough will be hot and slightly set, so be firm but gentle.
5. **Cover and return to the oven** – Put the lid back on and place the Dutch oven back inside. Finish baking as usual.

Warnings & Considerations

- **Work fast, but safely.** You don't want to lose too much heat, but don't rush to the point where you risk burning yourself.
- **Always use proper protection.** Heat-resistant gloves or mitts are essential—both the Dutch oven and the steam inside will be extremely hot.
- **Not necessary, but fun.** This technique isn't required for a good loaf, but if you enjoy playing

with scoring patterns, it’s a great way to enhance your bread’s appearance.

If you’ve ever wondered how some bakers get those exaggerated, layered scores that look like delicate petals or deep canyon ridges, this might be the trick they’re using. Give it a shot and see how it changes your loaves!

Now that you've mastered the art of baking and scoring your first basic loaf, let's tackle the inevitable question that plagues every sourdough baker: what happens when things don't go according to plan? In the next chapter, we'll explore troubleshooting techniques that will help you diagnose and fix common issues, starting with the foundation of every great loaf, your starter.

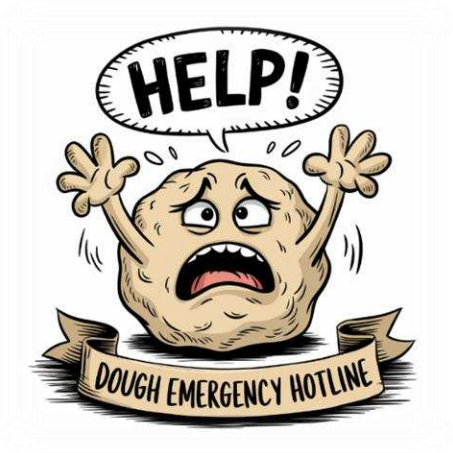
Chapter 4

Troubleshooting—Save My Dough!

“Is My Sourdough Starter Dead?!”

Spoiler: It’s probably not dead—just being dramatic.

Sourdough starters have a flair for the drama. One day, they’re lively and bubbly; the next, they look like they belong in a crime scene investigation. But don’t panic—starters are **survivors**, and in most cases, a little patience (and maybe some tough love) will bring yours back to life.



Common Signs Your Starter Needs CPR

💀 Mold Alert:

• Identification**:** If you observe fuzzy spots in colors like pink, green, black, or dark brown, it's a clear indication of mold.

• Action**:** Unfortunately, once mold is present, it's best to discard the entire starter and begin anew. Mold spores can penetrate deeply, making it unsafe to salvage any portion.

No Bubbles? Flat and lifeless?

- If it's been **3+ days of feeding with zero activity**, your yeast may be struggling.
- *Solution:* Try the **1:1:1 feeding method** (see below) and keep it **warm;** starters are lazy when it's too cold.

Remember, while it's disappointing to discard a starter, prioritizing health and safety is essential.

Smells Like Rotting Fruit or Gym Socks

- A super funky smell means the bacteria might be unbalanced.
- *Solution:* Feed it regularly, and if the smell persists, give it a break in the fridge for a few days to reset.

How to Revive a Neglected or "Dead" Starter

Step 1: Scrape Off the Hooch

- Hooch is the dark liquid that forms on top when a starter is hungry.
- You can **pour it off** (milder flavor) or **stir it back in** (more tang).

Step 2: The 1:1:1 Feeding Method (Starter CPR)

- Feed it **equal parts** starter, flour, and water:

✅ 10g starter + 10g flour + 10g water.

✅ Repeat every **12 hours** until you see bubbles.

Step 3: Give It Some Heat

Keeping your sourdough starter warm is key to getting it bubbly and active.

✅ **Why Warmth Matters:**

- Yeast and bacteria love temperatures between 75-82°F (24-28°C). Keeping your starter in this range helps it thrive.

✅ **How to Keep It Cozy:**

- Top of the Fridge: It's warm up there, making it a great spot for your starter.
- Near a Constantly Running Appliance: Placing your starter next to devices like a coffee maker can provide consistent warmth.
- Dedicated Starter Warmer: Devices like the Goldie by Sourhouse maintain the ideal temperature range for your starter.

Note: You'll often hear advice to place your starter in the oven with just the light on. While this can work, I've seen too many baked sourdough starters Because people forget and turn the oven on. For the safest bet, mark my words.

What If It’s Still Not Reviving?

If your starter is still refusing to wake up after 3-4 days, try these **emergency boosters**:

🚀 **Rye Flour Rescue:**

- Rye flour contains extra wild yeast—swap 50% of your regular flour with rye for a few feedings.

🍯 **Honey or Apple Juice Boost:**

- A teaspoon of **honey or unsweetened apple juice** can give the yeast extra food to kickstart activity. It's important to use these additions sparingly, regardless of your starter's volume. Too much can disrupt the natural balance between the yeast and bacteria,

🥶 **Fridge Reset:**

- Sometimes, letting it rest in the fridge for **a week without feeding** can help rebalance the bacteria.

Troubleshooting Quick Guide:

Is Your Starter REALLY Dead?

Problem	Cause	Fix
No bubbles after 3 days	Too cold, not enough food	Feed 1:1:1 and keep warm
Smells like acetone (nail polish remover)	Starter is starving	Feed twice daily for 2 days
Has a layer of black liquid	Very hungry	Stir in or pour off, then feed
Fluffy pink or black mold	Contamination	Toss and start fresh
Only bubbles, no rise	Weak gluten structure	Give it time, keep feeding
Doubles in size but collapses quickly	Overripe starter	Feed more often

Need More Help?

For an in-depth revival guide with **photos and step-by-step instructions**, check out my blog post:

BakingGreatBread.blog

📌 *"How to Revive a 'Dead' Sourdough Starter (It's Probably Not Dead)"*

Final Thought:

Patience is the #1 ingredient in sourdough. If your starter is struggling, don't give up! Starters are resilient. Treat it like a houseplant—feed it, keep it warm, and **don't overthink it**.

Soon, it'll be back to bubbling happily, ready to help you bake incredible bread.

With the troubleshooting skills to revive and maintain your starter, you're ready to tackle the next challenge of sourdough baking: finding a sustainable rhythm that works with your lifestyle. Because let's face it—even the most enthusiastic baker needs a schedule that doesn't require quitting their day job.

Chapter 5

Sourdough Schedules for Real Humans

Have you ever looked at a sourdough recipe and thought, *"Who has time for this?"*, you're not alone. Between work, family, and trying to maintain a social life (or at least remembering to water your houseplants), a long, unpredictable dough process can feel impossible. But the truth is, sourdough works for *you*—not the other way around.

Sourdough isn't about hovering over a bowl of flour for 12 hours. It's about understanding the rhythm of fermentation and finding a schedule that fits your life. Here are two foolproof plans tailored for busy humans:

The 9-to-5 Baker

For those juggling work, kids, or a packed schedule, this plan makes it possible to bake without missing a beat.

🕕 **6 AM** – Feed your starter before heading out for the day. (Bonus: Your kitchen smells like fresh yeast before your first cup of coffee.)

🕛 **12 PM (Lunch Break or Remote Work Perk)** – Mix the dough (fermentolyse). Let it rest for 30 minutes. Then, perform **three gentle coil folds**, one every 30 minutes, before getting back to your daily chaos.

🕔 **5 PM** – Shape the dough, pop it in the fridge, and forget about it.

🕕 **6 AM (Next Day)** – Bake while making your morning coffee. By the time you're out of the shower, your house smells like a bakery.

📌 **Best For:** People who work standard hours, parents managing school routines, or anyone who likes waking up to freshly baked bread.

The Weekend Warrior

For those who prefer a more relaxed, weekend-long bread therapy session, this schedule turns sourdough into a slow ritual.

🕗 **Friday 8 PM** – Feed your starter before bed. Consider tucking your dough baby in for the night.

🕗 **Saturday 8 AM** – Mix the dough. Let it **rest for 30 minutes**, then perform **three gentle coil folds**, one every 30 minutes. After the last fold, let the dough **bulk ferment** for several hours while you sip coffee and debate what to do with your weekend.

🕑 **Saturday 2 PM** – Shape the dough and put it in the fridge for a **cold overnight proof**. You're free to binge-watch a show, clean your kitchen (or not), or take a nap.

🕗 **Sunday 9 AM** – Bake. Reward yourself with a homemade brunch. **Bonus points** if you top your toast with butter and jam while still in pajamas.

📌 **Best For:** Those who enjoy a slower, more meditative baking process—weekend vibes only.

More Schedules for Real Life

Because not everyone fits into these two categories, here are some alternative timelines:

✅ **The Night Owl:**

Feed your starter at 10 PM, mix at midnight, bulk ferment overnight, shape at 8 AM, and bake in the evening. *Perfect for those who love late-night creativity.*

✅ **The Forgetful Baker:**

Did you forget to feed your starter? Try a quick boost: Warm your starter (next to a lamp or in a proofing box) and double feed it. You can still bake that same evening.

✅ **The Road Warrior:**

Traveling? As bakers, we sometimes go to great lengths to keep our sourdough starters active, even when life takes us on the road. Some folks dehydrate their starters to bring

them along on trips others just try to hide it. I've even heard of a baker who smuggled her starter across the border by hiding it in her bra! Only in these cases is it acceptable to measure your starter in cups.

Sourdough Doesn’t Judge—Find What Works for You

The beauty of sourdough is that it’s adaptable. If you oversleep, miss a step, or get distracted, your dough will *probably* forgive you. The key is working with the process, not fighting against it. So, pick a schedule, trust the dough,

and enjoy the magic of homemade bread—no matter how busy you are.

Now that you have practical schedules to fit sourdough into your life, let's take a moment to understand what's actually happening in that bowl of dough. Don't worry, I promised minimal nerdiness, and I'll deliver. Understanding just a bit of the science behind sourdough will take your baking from good to consistently great.

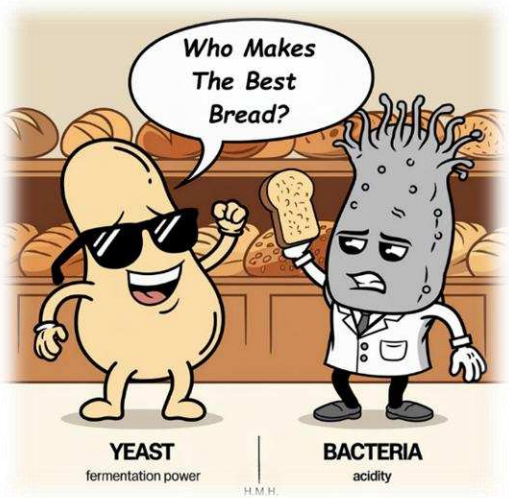
Chapter 6

Sourdough Science (Minimal Nerdiness, Maximum Results)

Science and baking go hand in hand, but don't worry, you won't need a lab coat for this chapter. Understanding just **a little bit** of the science behind sourdough can take your bread from "meh" to *magic*.

Fermentation 101: Yeast vs. Bacteria

At its core, sourdough is a **battle of microscopic giants**—yeast and bacteria—working together to transform flour and water into a living, breathing dough. Here's how they make the magic happen:



🍞 **Yeast: The Gas Machine**

- Eat sugar in the flour.
- Produces **CO_2 gas**, which creates bubbles and makes dough rise.
- Loves warm temperatures (but too hot, and it throws a tantrum and dies).

🧪 **Bacteria: The Flavor Masters (The Good Bacteria)**

- Also eat sugars, but instead of gas, they produce **lactic acid (mild tang)** and **acetic acid (sharp tang).**
- Slower than yeast, but their work gives sourdough its unique taste.
- Loves a colder environment—thrives in the fridge for a long, slow ferment.

Science Lite: How Temperature Affects Fermentation

⚡ **Warm Temps (75–80°F / 24–27°C):**

- **Yeast party!** Dough rises faster but has a milder flavor.
- Great for soft sandwich loaves or quick bakes.

❄️ **Cool Temps (Fridge Proofing, 38–45°F / 3–7°C):**

- **Bacteria takeover.** Dough rises slowly, developing a sharper tang.
- Best for rustic, deeply flavored loaves.

📌 **Pro Tip:** For a **balanced** loaf with good rise and flavor, let your dough rise at room temp for a few hours, then cold-proof overnight.

2. Baker's Percentage: The Secret Language of Bread

Ever see a recipe that says **75% hydration** and feel lost? No worries, this is just **a simple math trick** that bakers use to adjust recipes **without guesswork**.

What It Is:

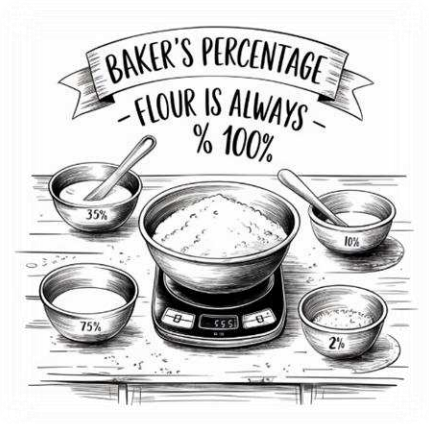
Instead of measuring ingredients by cups or spoons, bakers use **percentages based on flour weight**.

- The **total flour weight is always 100%**, and everything else is calculated relative to it.

Example: A basic sourdough recipe might look like this:

Ingredient	Grams	% of Flour Weight
Flour	500g	100%
Water	375g	75% (hydration level)
Starter	100g	20%
Salt	10g	2%

Why It Matters:



📌 **Want a softer, easier-to-handle dough?** Lower hydration (60–65%).

📌 **Want an open, airy crumb?** Higher hydration (75–85%).

📌 **Want more control over your bakes?** This method makes it easy to scale up or down without ruining ratios.

Sourdough = Delicious Chemistry

Sourdough isn’t about strict rules, it’s about **understanding the balance between fermentation and structure**. The more you experiment with temperature, hydration, and timing, the better your loaves will get.

👨‍🔬 **Key Takeaways:**

✅ Warmer = faster rise, milder flavor.

✅ Colder = slower rise, tangier flavor.

✅ Hydration controls **texture**—adjust based on the loaf you want.

So, next time you mix up a batch, remember **you're not just baking bread, you're playing with edible science.** 🥖🔬

Now that you understand the science behind what makes sourdough work, let's put this knowledge into practice. The basic recipe we covered earlier is just the beginning, with a few simple tweaks, you can transform your artisan loaf into different styles of bread to suit any occasion or preference. Let's explore how to customize your sourdough, starting with a family favorite: the soft sandwich loaf.

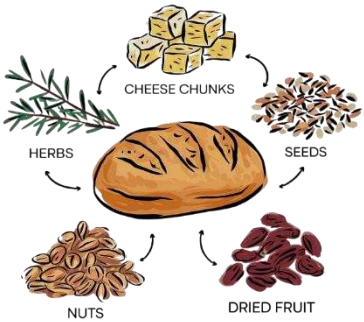
Chapter 7

Recipe Variations—Make It Yours

Soft Sandwich Sourdough (Loaf Pan Method)

Why This Works

This variation transforms your rustic sourdough into a tender, sliceable sandwich loaf. By baking in a loaf pan, you'll get a soft crust and even rise, perfect for sandwiches, toast, or slathering with jam. The honey and milk add subtle sweetness and soften the crumb, while the pan traps steam naturally for a golden top.



Ingredients

(Yields one 9x5-inch loaf)

Ingredient	Metric	Volume (approx.)
Bread flour	500g	4 cups
Water (lukewarm)	325g	1 ⅓ cups
Whole milk	50g	3 tbsp + 1 tsp
Active sourdough starter	100g	½ cup
Salt	10g	2 tsp
Honey or maple syrup	21g	1 tbsp

Equipment

- 9x5-inch loaf pan (light-colored metal or glass)
- Mixing bowl
- Bench scraper
- Digital scale
- Brød & Taylor Baking Shell (*affiliate link*) or Dutch oven (optional, for steaming)

Method

1. Mix & Fermentolyse

- In a large bowl, combine **500g flour**, **325g water**, **50g milk**, **100g starter**, and **21g honey**. Mix until no dry flour remains.
- Cover and rest for **45 minutes**.
- Add **10g salt**. Mix using the **Rubaud method** (5–7 minutes) until dough is smooth.

2. Bulk Fermentation

- Perform **3 sets of coil folds** every 45 minutes.
- Let dough rise until **50% increase in volume** (3–4 hours at 75°F).

3. Shape for the Pan

- Lightly grease the loaf pan with butter or oil.
- Turn dough onto a floured surface. Flatten into a rectangle, fold sides inward, then roll tightly from top to bottom.
- Place seam-side down in the pan.

4. Proof

- Cover and proof at room temp until **1 inch above the pan rim** (1–2 hours).

- *Optional cold proof*: Refrigerate overnight for tangier flavor.

5. Bake

- Preheat oven to **375°F (190°C)**.
- Brush loaf with milk or melted butter for a soft crust.
- Bake **30–35 minutes** until golden and internal temp reaches **190°F (88°C)**.
- Cool in the pan for 10 minutes, then transfer to a wire rack.

Key Differences: Pan vs. Open Bake

Aspect	Loaf Pan	Open Bake (Dutch Oven)
Crust	Soft, golden, tender	Crispy, blistered, artisanal
Crumb	Tight, even, perfect for slicing	Open, airy holes
Steam	Trapped by pan walls	Requires Dutch oven/ice cubes
Shaping	Rolled log for structure	Round/oval for tension

Troubleshooting

Issue	Cause	Solution
Dense crumb	Underproofed	Extend the final proof until dough rises 1" above pan.
Collapsed top	Overproofed	Reduce proof time; dough should spring back lightly when poked.

Issue	Cause	Solution
Pale crust	Oven too cool	Ensure the oven is fully preheated; brush with milk before baking.

Nutrition Facts

(Per slice, ~50g)

Calories	Carbs	Protein	Fat
120	24g	4g	1g

(Note: Slightly higher fat due to milk.)

Why This Belongs in Your Repertoire

This recipe showcases how small tweaks—**lower hydration**, **added dairy/sweetener**, and **shaping for a pan**—can transform your sourdough into a versatile everyday staple. Baking in a loaf pan removes the guesswork of scoring and steam management, making it ideal for beginners or those craving a softer crumb.

Pro Tip

For extra-fluffy bread, replace 50g flour with 50g tangzhong (water roux).

Ready to Bake?

Tag **#HenryHunter** with your sandwich loaf—we'd love to see what you make!

Chapter 8

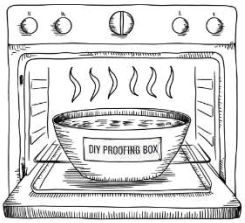
Tools & Hacks (No Fancy Gear Needed)

Budget Gear

- **No Dutch Oven?** Use a cast-iron skillet + stainless steel bowl.
- **No Banneton?** Line a bowl with a floured tea towel.

DIY Proofing Box

- Oven + light on + bowl of boiling water = 80°F paradise.



Pro Tools (Affiliate Links)

1. **Brød & Taylor Folding Proofer**
    - **Perfect for**:
        - *Controlled fermentation* (set exact temps for sourdough or yeast).
        - *Slow cooking, yogurt, sous vide, and even tempering chocolate.*

- **Why Bakers Love It**:
  - Folds flat for storage (no counter space hog!).
  - Consistent results in any kitchen, any season.
  - *Power*: 120V~, 50/60Hz.
  - **Pro Tip:** Use it to revive sluggish starters in winter or proof dough overnight while you sleep.

2. **Brød & Taylor Baking Shell**
   - Lightweight alternative to a Dutch oven.
3. **ModKitchn Bread Sling**

Tools can help you bake better bread, but the heart of sourdough baking is community—sharing successes, laughing at failures, and learning from each other's experiences. Let's take a look at some real stories from fellow bakers who've been exactly where you are now.

Chapter 9

Community Corner—Bread Wins & Fails

One of the best parts of baking sourdough isn't just the bread, it's the **stories**. Every baker has their fair share of **disasters, victories, and weird experiments** that somehow worked out. Whether you nailed an open crumb loaf or ended up with something that resembled a doorstop, you're in good company.

Here's a collection of real stories from fellow bakers. Some will inspire you; some will make you laugh, and some might even save you from making the same mistakes.

🏆 Member Stories: Bread Wins"

I baked sourdough during a power outage—used my grill!" *— Rebecca, Colorado*

🔥 When the power went out, Rebecca didn't let her dough go to waste.

She threw it on the grill, created a makeshift steam setup, and ended up with a **beautifully charred, rustic loaf**. *Pro tip: If you ever must do this, use indirect heat and a pan of water to help with steam.*

"My starter survived a road trip… in my bra." —Mia, Oregon

👜 Who needs luggage when you have body heat? Mia refused to let her hard-earned starter die, so she kept it warm while traveling across-country. Shockingly, it made it. *Moral of the story: Sourdough bakers will go to great lengths to protect their yeast babies.*

"Taught my 7-year-old to bake, and now we have a weekly 'bread night'!" —Carlos, Florida

👩‍👧 Carlos turned baking into a **family tradition**, and now his kid measures flour better than most adults. *Sourdough isn't just food, it's a memory-maker.*

#BreadFails

The Ones That Didn’t Quite Rise to the Occasion

Because we all have them.

🧐 **"I forgot salt. Ate it anyway. 0/10."** —Dave, Group Member
(Spoiler: Salt isn’t optional.)

🔥 **"Tried to rush the process by baking at 500°F the whole time. My loaf was…black."** —Lena, Toronto
(Lena may have invented sourdough charcoal.)

🥖 **"My first baguette turned out so hard, I could’ve used it as a baseball bat."** —Jordan, UK
(Some loaves are meant to be admired, not eaten.)

Closing

The Sourdough Mindset

Sourdough teaches you **to trust the process**—even when things don't go as planned. Some days your starter is thriving, some days it's a diva. Some loaves are bakery-level perfection, others belong in a museum of failures.

But that's the beauty of it.

Baking sourdough is about learning, adapting, and **embracing the unexpected**. Keep baking, keep sharing, and remember: **The best bread is the one you make.**

Now, go bake something amazing.

Additional Resources

📖 **Read More on the Blog**
Baking Great Bread at Home: https://bakinggreatbread.blog

👥 **Join Our Community**
Facebook Group: Baking Great Bread at Home: https://www.facebook.com/groups/BakingGreatBreadAtHome

Ready to Rise?

Post your first loaf in *Baking Great Bread at Home* and tag **#HenryHunter**—we'll cheer you on!

Books by Henry Hunter

📚 *Sourdough for the Rest of Us* – Download Here: https://hunter53.gumroad.com/l/tejdc

📚 *Bread: A Journey Through History, Science, Art, and Community* – Amazon: https://a.co/d/4UCIwap

📚 *Vitale Sourdough Mastery* – Amazon: https://a.co/d/1HBuy64

📚 *From Oven to Market: Selling Bread at Farmers' Markets & Beyond* – Amazon: https://a.co/d/9ebJdSZ

📚 *The Yeast Water Handbook* – Amazon: https://a.co/d/4muwBEV